

5 June 2026, Auckland, New Zealand

A New Zealand software engineer is publicly betting his NZ\$1.5 million house that no one will perfectly predict the 2026 FIFA World Cup, and the bet is open to anyone, anywhere

In a week when the biggest sporting event on Earth kicks off in Mexico, Canada and the United States, an Auckland software developer is putting his entire property on the line as the prize in a free, global prediction game he built solo in three weeks.

Tim Thomas (+64 21 535 832, info@tournamental.com) is the founder of **Tournamental** (play.tournamental.com), a tamper-proof FIFA World Cup bracket-prediction platform. The promise is simple: if any single person, anywhere in the world, correctly predicts the result of all 104 matches at FIFA World Cup 2026, Thomas will sell his Auckland home, pay off the bank, and wire the net cash proceeds (an estimated **NZ\$700,000** at today's valuation) to the winner.

The platform launches publicly seven days before the opening match on 11 June.

"A team of six developers would have taken six months to build this two years ago. AI tooling let me do it solo in three weeks," said Thomas. "The tournament is the biggest sporting event on Earth. Every breakfast show, every football podcast, every workplace Slack channel is going to be talking about it for five weeks. I've built the engagement layer they can drop straight in, free, branded as theirs, and I'm betting my house that nobody can beat the maths."

The full long-form letter from the founder is published at play.tournamental.com/the-bet, with the probability working at play.tournamental.com/odds and the public terms at play.tournamental.com/terms/house-prize.

Help your audience steal Tim's house

Any TV show, radio station, podcast, newspaper or influencer covering the World Cup can spin up a free, branded Tournamental pool in five minutes and put it in front of their audience as a five-week engagement hook. The pitch writes itself: every listener, viewer or reader who joins the pool is one bracket closer to being the person who wins Tim's house.

The branded pool keeps the show's logo, colours, and presenter copy. The leaderboard updates live. The audience can edit picks all the way up to each match's kickoff. The show gets daily on-air talking points ("76% of you picked Brazil to beat Croatia, here's what changed today") and five weeks of guaranteed audience return.

If one of the show's audience members happens to be the one in 10 thousand trillion trillion who nails 104 from 104, the keys to Tim's house get wired to them via Tournamental.

"I want broadcasters to encourage their audiences to take my house off me," said Thomas. "If someone wins, I lose the house but I'd love to know I gave it away off the back of a podcast or a breakfast show. That's the dream version of this story."

Why the bet exists

Thomas, who has been building websites and apps for 26 years and runs Growth Spurt, an Auckland-based web agency, says the bet is the fastest way for a single solo developer to be heard above the noise of other product launches in June 2026.

"I'm not insured. I'm not running a sweepstake. I built the system, I know the maths, and I'd rather skin in the game than skin in an insurance broker's fine print. If someone nails 104 from 104, the bank gets paid out of the sale, the winner gets the cheque, and I'm moving back in with mum at age 50."

The maths is the story

There are 104 matches in the 2026 FIFA World Cup. The group stage accounts for 72 of those, each with three possible outcomes (home win, draw, away win). The knockout rounds account for the remaining 32 matches, each with two possible outcomes (the team that progresses, or the team that does not).

The total number of distinct possible 104-match brackets is therefore 3 to the power of 72, multiplied by 2 to the power of 32. The answer is a number with **44 digits**, approximately 9.74 followed by 43 zeros.

For context, ESPN has run a March Madness bracket challenge since 1998, with millions of entries every single year. Each ESPN bracket covers 63 matches, with two possible outcomes per match (basketball, no draws). The total combinatorial space for an ESPN bracket is 2 to the power of 63, approximately 9.2 quintillion. In 27 years of ESPN tracking, **nobody has ever submitted a perfect bracket**.

Tournamental has 104 matches, and a combinatorial space approximately 10 thousand trillion trillion times larger.

The full working is at play.tournamental.com/odds.

How it stays honest

Every match kickoff, Tournamental hashes the entire predictions database and commits the hash to the **Bitcoin blockchain** via OpenTimestamps. The script is open-source. The audit trail is publicly verifiable at play.tournamental.com/verify.

If Thomas (or any external attacker) altered a single pick after a match kicked off, the new hash would not match the on-chain commitment, and any auditor could prove it within minutes using a public command-line tool. Picks become immutable the moment their match kicks off, on the authority of the Bitcoin blockchain.

The full source code is open under Apache 2.0 at github.com/0800tim/tournamental and is self-hostable by any organisation that wants to run its own pool under its own infrastructure.

Product points

- Free to play. No app install, no password. Sign in by WhatsApp, SMS, email or Telegram one-time code.
- 104 picks per player across the full bracket: groups, R32, R16, quarter-finals, semi-finals, third-place play-off, final.
- Picks can be edited at any time, locking only when each individual match kicks off. (Other bracket apps lock everything at the opening match.)
- Real-time leaderboards per pool, per country, globally and against friends.
- 3D match-molecule renders every fixture as predicted.
- 21 languages including English, Spanish, French, German, Portuguese (Brazil and Portugal), Italian, Japanese, Korean, Simplified Chinese, Arabic, and te reo Māori.
- Custom-branded pools. Logo, colours, prize copy, optional country gating. Two minutes to set up. No engineering needed.
- Optional prize pools. Pool owners can offer sponsored prizes, set entry fees and pot splits, or run free pools for pure engagement.

The platform is free for accredited media partners through the 2026 cycle.

Eligibility for the house prize

Open globally to anyone 18 or over. Free to enter. The only condition is that entrants register with a valid mobile phone number and verify the one-time code, so the Promoter can confirm eligibility if there is a winner. Picks lock at each match's kickoff. Full terms at play.tournamental.com/terms/house-prize.

Privacy and trust

No passwords stored. No third-party ad tracking. No data sale to external parties. New Zealand-based operations.

About

Tournamental is a subsidiary of Growth Spurt Ltd, a technology company based in Auckland, New Zealand. The platform is open-source under the Apache 2.0 licence.

Founder available for interview

Tim Thomas is available for live and recorded interviews from Auckland on short notice over the seven days leading up to the tournament, and throughout the tournament itself. He can speak to:

- The build (three weeks, solo, AI-assisted)
- The bet (mortgage, equity, why no insurance)
- The technology (open-source, blockchain audit trail, anti-tamper)
- The product (five-week engagement layer for any broadcaster, and "help your audience steal Tim's house" as the segment hook)

Press contact

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ENDS